realized that the politics of fasts and dharnas was subject to diminishing returns, was excited at the prospect. Two days later, Anna backed out of the proposal, leading to complete confusion in the ranks. ‘We had made all the plans and then Anna ditched us,’ is how one Kejriwal aide described it.

Why did Anna not eventually support Kejriwal’s political party? My sense is that Kejriwal was itching to change the scope of his movement and coerced Anna initially into endorsing the idea of a political party. Anna relished the attention being showered on him but he was clever enough to know that he derived his power from staying away from formal politics. Kejriwal, though, was always a man in a tearing hurry.

A few weeks later, Kejriwal decided to gherao the homes of Sonia Gandhi and Nitin Gadkari, alleging a Congress–BJP collusion in the coal scam. ‘But when we went to seek Dr Bedi’s support, she refused to endorse the move to protest at the BJP president’s house. She wanted us to only target the Congress,’ Kejriwal later told me. Bedi countered, ‘The movement was losing focus. We could not equate the Congress and the BJP all the time.’ A break was now inevitable in the original Team Anna.

On 24 November 2012, the Aam Aadmi Party was formed by Team Kejriwal. Anna decided to keep out, as did Dr Bedi. A fledgling party created without their mascot Anna and with limited resources, Kejriwal’s political experiment was given hardly any chance of succeeding by people. I was among the sceptics. When my friend and political scientist Yogendra Yadav, who used to do our election programming at CNN-IBN, told me of his decision to join the new party, I gently suggested he might be making a big mistake. ‘Politics is a different cup of tea, Yogendra, this won’t work. Why do you want to give up the studio for the street?’ I asked. The next twelve months would prove all of us sceptics very wrong.

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The spectacular rise of the AAP from neophyte party to the ruling power in Delhi rewrote all the rules of electoral politics. Instant success in politics is rare. N.T. Rama Rao’s Telugu Desam won its debut election in 1983 riding